

FREE SAMPLE

Tarantula Care Package

The first 5 pages of the 44-page printable manual, free to keep.



In this sample: What's inside, How to Use This Package, Quick Profile, Cost Overview. The contents page shows every one of the 44 pages, so you can see exactly what the full package covers before you buy it.

Not in this sample: the 39 pages that follow, which are the full care guide, the health section, the quick reference cards, and the owner tools, checklists and logs.

The full package is \$8.99 at beastlyfacts.com/care-packages/tarantula/. One purchase, and every corrected edition is a free re-download from your library. The free tarantula care guide it was built from is at beastlyfacts.com/guides/tarantula/, and stays free.

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What's inside

Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

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START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

If you haven't set up yet

Read pages 4 through 9 before buying anything, and read page 28 before you buy the spider. The enclosure decision is the one that kills tarantulas: an enclosure taller than it is wide gives a heavy-bodied spider somewhere to fall from, and a fall ruptures an abdomen. Get the shape right, get the substrate deep, and put a water dish in from day one. Then use the Budget & Shopping List on page 31.

If your tarantula is already set up

Go to the Setup Checklist on page 29 and audit what you have, paying particular attention to fall height and substrate depth. If your spider has stopped eating, do not panic: go to page 12 first, because in this species a refused meal is usually normal rather than a symptom. If it has a shrivelled abdomen or is sitting with its legs curled beneath it, that is the genuine emergency, and it is page 24.

Print these first

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| ☐ Page 29: Setup Checklist & Targets | ☐ Page 37: Pet-Sitter Sheet |
| ☐ Page 30: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 38: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 33: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 39: Acquisition & Molt Log |
| ☐ Page 34: Daily, Weekly & Seasonal Routine | ☐ Page 41: Enrichment Checklist & Log |

WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

Tarantula keeping is refreshingly simple and unusually easy to get wrong in a few specific ways, most of them invisible until the spider is dead. It is also a hobby with very little veterinary backstop, which puts more weight on husbandry than on treatment. This package sets out what is actually known, including the single controlled housing study on page 21 reported with its unflattering findings intact, cross-checked against the sources listed on page 43.

BUY THE SPECIES, NOT THE LOOK

Ask the seller what the species is, in Latin, and look up its type before you buy the enclosure. "Tarantula" covers animals with genuinely incompatible needs, and a shop selling a fossorial baboon spider in a shallow display tank is not a reliable guide.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

An exotics vet who treats invertebrates, where one exists. Many areas simply do not have one, which is the honest situation and the reason this book leans hard on prevention. Find out now whether anyone within reach will see a tarantula, and write it on page 30. Experienced keeper communities are the realistic second line, and they are genuinely useful, but they are not a diagnosis.

SECTION 01

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Family	Theraphosidae, over 900 species on every continent except Antarctica
Adult size	2 to 12 in (5 to 30 cm) leg span depending on species. A Chilean rose hair sits around 4.5 to 5.5 in (11 to 14 cm)
Lifespan	Females commonly 15 to 20 years or more. Males typically 4 to 7 years total, because they stop molting at maturity
Native range	Tropics and subtropics worldwide. Desert, grassland, rainforest floor, and canopy depending on the species
Diet type	Obligate carnivore, ambush predator, live insect prey only. No formulated diet exists (page 10)
Enclosure minimum	About 3× the leg span in floor width, roughly 20×10×10 in (50×25×25 cm) for an adult, and horizontal
The one hard rule	Keep it low. Height is the danger, floor area is the benefit, and a fall ruptures an abdomen (page 6)
Housing	One per enclosure. Most species are solitary and cannibalistic, and no enclosure size fixes that
Handling	Strictly look, don't touch. The risk runs in both directions (pages 15 and 17)
Legal status	Legal in most of the US, banned in a handful of places. Check page 28 before you buy
Conservation	Varies. Many species are CITES Appendix II, some are Endangered. Buy captive-bred

SECTION 01

Cost overview

A tarantula is arguably the cheapest long-lived exotic pet there is. The commitment is measured in years, not dollars.

Cost overview

Initial setup

\$70 to \$300 for the enclosure, substrate, hide, water dish and tongs, plus \$25 to \$100 for the spider. A Chilean rose hair or curly hair is usually \$20 to \$50, and slings cost less than adults.

Ongoing

\$5 to \$15 a month, essentially all of it feeder insects, so roughly \$60 to \$180 a year. There is no pet insurance for tarantulas and very little routine vet cost.

THE REAL NUMBER TO SIT WITH

Not the money, the years. A female is a 15 to 20 year commitment and sometimes longer, on a budget most pets would spend in a month. This is arguably the cheapest long-lived exotic pet there is, which makes the time commitment the thing to think through properly before buying, rather than the price.

Fun facts worth knowing

- They digest food outside their bodies. A tarantula injects enzymes through its fangs to liquefy the prey's insides, then a muscular sucking stomach pumps the liquid meal in, leaving the empty exoskeleton behind as a small pellet called a bolus.
- Females never stop molting. Most invertebrates stop once they mature; a female tarantula keeps shedding for life, which is a large part of why she outlives a male three or four times over.
- Their blood is not contained. Hemolymph flows freely through the body cavity and bathes the organs directly rather than running in vessels, which is exactly why even a moderate abdominal rupture turns fatal so fast (page 24).